

# THE PEOPLE'S RAILWAYS

The railways picked up the pieces after Partition and looked towards a young, free India as it sought to actively be a part of nation-building. To do so, however, it first had to go through the long process of restructuring its operational units and build new lines to properly connect the country so that it could truly become the “Lifeline to the Nation” – its slogan today.



▲ **The palatial Churchgate station** building in Mumbai serves as the main office of the Western Railway, created by merging Bombay, Baroda and Central India (BB&CI) Railway with several other lines.

The early decades following Independence saw the railways' transition from a colonial tool to an enterprise that contributed to the larger agenda of nation-building, all the while serving the interests of India and its people. This was the time that the country's “greatest national asset” – as Jawaharlal Nehru, the first prime minister of India, called the railways in April 1952 – experienced a rebirth that helped it become a true lifeline to the country. If the 1950s were a time of integration and reorganization for the railways, the 1960s and 1970s were about modernization, increasing capacity, and building new lines.

## A matter of zones

One of the earliest steps was to reorganize and better integrate its operational centres, which served 42 different railway systems. These included 13 Class I railways, so designated because of annual gross